First News

19 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

U.S. stocks closed sharply lower after the Federal Reserve signaled fewer rate cuts ahead, while rising oil prices fueled renewed inflation fears. Dow fell 1.6%, the S&P 500 dropped 1.4%, and the Nasdaq 100 slid 1.4% as volatility surged and investors moved to risk-off mode.

- Wall Street slid, led by a 1.26% drop in the Dow Jones (-592.59 pts) and a 0.83% decline in the S&P 500. This bearish sentiment is underscored by an 8.17% spike in the CBOE Vix Volatility to 119.58, indicating extreme investor fear.

The Fed held rates steady as Middle East tensions & $108+ oil fuel market uncertainty. With only one rate cut signaled for 2026/2027 & inflation data spooking investors, stocks opened lower while the FX market dipped. Policymakers cautious, risky path forward

Oil surged while metals tumbled as geopolitical tensions tightened energy supply expectations.

- Brent Crude Oil jumped above $108 and Crude Oil climbed, stronger U.S. Dollar Index pressured metals — sending Gold, Silver, & Copper lower as investors rotated toward energy & US$

WTI crude jumped as much as 3.3% to hit $98.60 a barrel, while Brent settled near $107. Meanwhile, Europe's natural gas benchmark climbed 6% on Wednesday.

Comments from US President Donald Trump that he does not need cooperation from NATO or other countries "actually reassured markets in the sense that the situation may not escalate into a full-scale war," said Hitoshi Asaoka, a chief strategist at Asset Management One.

Asian energy stocks are positioned for gains as global markets react to a major missile attack by Iran on Qatar's Ras Laffan Industrial City, the world's largest liquefied natural gas (LNG) export hub
Watch:: PCOR SHLPH PNX AP MER SCC SPC ACEN ALTER CREIT RASLAG NEXTGEN SGP

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/18/2026	3/19/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	46,993	46,225	-1.63%
S&P 500	6,716	6,625	-1.36%
NASDAQ	22,480	22,152	-1.46%
PCOMP	6,026.01	6,055.45	0.49%
NKY	54,435.67	55,239.00	1.48%
SHCOMP	4049.91	4062.98	0.32%
HSI	25,868.54	26,025.00	0.60%
KOSPI	5849.44	5925	1.29%
SENSEX	76,070.84	76,704.00	0.83%
TWSE	33,837	34,348	1.51%
ASX200	8617.4	8640.64	0.27%
BURSAKLCI	1710.99	1729.81	1.10%
JCI	7106.84	7106.84	0.00%
STI	4935.97	5002.17	1.34%
SET	953.66	955.82	0.23%
VNINDEX	1710.29	1713.83	0.21%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/18/2026	3/19/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	94.76	99.67	5.18%
Brent Crude	102.36	111.85	9.27%
Gold (Comex)	5007.9	4845	-3.25%
Silver (Comex)	79.2	76.59	-3.30%
Platinum Spot	2142.95	2044.62	-4.59%
Copper (Comex)	576.1	551.6	-4.25%
Nickel	7.7867	7.7066	-1.03%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	65	80	23.08%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	79.5	94.5	18.87%
Coal	134.75	139.35	3.41%
Corn	455.5	466	2.31%
Wheat	591	608.75	3.00%
Cocoa	3349	3260	-2.66%
Sugar	14.45	14.8	2.42%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Strategy

Philippines

Philippines shares advanced 0.50% as investors piled into property, industrials, conglomerates & services looking past geopolitical uncertainty with oil extending its decline.

Philippine peso leads most Asian currencies higher as the decline in oil prices boosts sentiment across fuel-importing nations.

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control,

6055 +29.44 pts., +0.49%

Range 5998.21 - 6,055.45

Breadth 113 (+) 81 (-) 61 (unch)

Block Php857K **Volume 930**M
Value Php6.06B

Share buyback sm ict opm spmh meg

52wk H: dhi hti
52wk L ab ali apc ara bloom dito ferro idc medic shng sm vlc

Overbought – dhi fjp
Oversold – lbc pha bpi ferro pmpc tugs vlc tech fli shng ali sm brn pal

Active	Value
ICT	998
BDO	530
MBT	303
ALI	252
SM	237
MYNLD	179
APX	176
BPI	162
DHI	162

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$11.151mn
Total FB Feb	$455K
YTD NFB	$225.365mn

FB	2,994,578,102.83
FS	3,658,623,852.97
NFB(S)	664,045,750.14
TOTAL	6,653,201,955.80

Foreign Funds Bought
ew dhi ap fgen fph mer mwc spnec cnpf keepr aba ac aev jgs ltg smc mrc mreit rcr rlc dito glo ceb mac sti plus apx nikl px

Foreign Funds Sold
bdo bpi cbc mbt secb pse acen alter crec mynld pcor scc sgp dnl emi fb gsmi jfc monde rfm urc imi agi dmc gtcap sm ali areit cli dd smph tel cnvrg ict web pgold rrhi sevn ssi wlcon at ogp pxp

SmartWatch Tuesday 3/17/26
ICT AP WEB MRC DMC RCR BDO BPI AC JGS MYNLD MWC AC AP STI COSCO NEG MAC NIKL AP

10yr Bond	3/18/20...	3/19/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.748	6.748	0.00%
US	4.235	4.279	1.04%

Currency Pair	3/18/2...	3/19/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	159.29	159.45	0.64%
USD-PHP	59.898	59.53	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8917	6.8853	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1492	1.1522	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

SM 627.00
SMPH 19.90

- Buyback Transactions
- Updates its $3.0b European medium-term note program through their SG Holdings subsidiaries, to tap international bond markets for expansion. Move supports ₱100B capex for 2026, which includes new mall developments and refinancing needs.

SMPH 19.90

- **SM Prime to Open 90th Mall in Zamboanga; 4 Malls Targeted for 2026**
- SM Prime will open SM City Zamboanga on March 20 — its 8th mall in Mindanao and 90th nationwide. The four-level development adds over 42,000 sqm of gross leasable space and is the first of four mall openings planned for 2026, alongside SM General Trias, SM Tagum, and SM Santa Rosa. SM Prime reported FY2025 net income of P48.8B (+7%), with commercial property revenues rising 6% to P98.6B.
- **Analysis:** The Zamboanga opening is strategically meaningful — it signals the group's confidence in Mindanao's consumer market at a time when many developers are still Metro Manila-centric. The four-mall opening slate for 2026 adds incremental rental income and reinforces SMPH's GLA growth trajectory. The 7% net income growth, however, is modest given the scale of operations, reflecting pressure from rising costs. The BSP rate hike risk flagged by SM Chair Tessie Sy-Coson is a near-term headwind for the stock, higher rates compress REIT and property valuations and dampen consumer spending.
- ACCUMULATE on dips. SM Prime's scale, Mindanao expansion momentum, and stable commercial revenues are structural positives. Rate hike risk is a near-term overhang.

SMC 70.00

- Debt Refinancing: Funds will be used to settle existing debt obligations. SEC has officially cleared San Miguel Global Power Holdings Corp. (SMGP) to proceed with a ₱30 billion bond offering

PLUS 18.08

- DigiPlus reports ₱12.6B net profit for FY, FY25 growth was flat. PLUS declares ₱3.8 billion dividends, a₱12.6 billion

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PSE 203.00

- **Firm on P170B Capital-Raising Target Despite Market Uncertainties**
- PSE President Ramon Monzon reaffirmed the exchange's P170B capital-raising target for 2026, up from P144.14B raised in 2025 — itself a 75% jump from the prior year. The target includes about four IPOs, with GCash cited as the headline deal. Monzon noted that capital-raising activity is likely on hold until geopolitical conditions stabilize, and expressed hope the Middle East conflict eases within two months. The PSEi had been within 90 points of a technical bull market as recently as late February before the regional conflict stalled momentum, shifting flows from significant net foreign buying back toward caution.
- Analysis: Monzon's reaffirmation is more aspirational than actionable at this point. The PSEi's -1.43% close yesterday and continued geopolitical overhang (Brent above $100) make near-term listings difficult. GCash remains the transformative catalyst, but its filing is contingent on the SEC lowering the public float rule, which hasn't been formalized yet. The exchange's structural reform agenda (short-selling, new REIT rules) remains intact and is a medium-term market depth positive. Analysts note the target is achievable but "leans optimistic" given last year's execution shortfall (2 IPOs vs. 6 targeted).
- ACCUMULATE on PSE for medium-term. Market development pipeline is intact. Near-term execution depends on geopolitical and rate hike resolution.

MER 612.00

- **MER (Meralco) — Chairman Pangilinan: Capex Unlikely to Be Reduced**
- Meralco Chairman Manuel Pangilinan confirmed the group's 2026 capex program will likely be retained in full, covering both Meralco's distribution utility (P26B–P30B) and MGEN's generation investments. For 2025, total group capex reached P108.9B — more than double 2024 — with ~P80B going to the MTerra Solar project and P28.5B to distribution. The 2026 distribution capex covers new connections, asset renewals, load growth, and regulatory reset preparation ahead of the First Regulatory Period (1RP) starting July 2026.
- **Analysis:** This is a clear management signal of conviction in Meralco's investment cycle — no pullback despite geopolitical uncertainty and rising cost pressures. Maintaining capex at these levels is constructive for long-term earnings: MTerra Solar's commissioning (Phase 1) is the key 2026 profit catalyst, and the regulatory reset (1RP July 2026–June 2030) locks in a new revenue framework. The combination of a capex-intensive infrastructure buildout and a pending rate case makes MER a medium-term earnings compounding story — though near-term FCF will remain compressed.
- ACCUMULATE. Capex commitment + regulatory reset + RE commissioning = strong medium-term earnings driver. BUY ON WEAKNESS given broader market volatility.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

ROCK 1.81

- **ROCK (Rockwell Land) — Lists P10B Bonds on PDEx; 5x Oversubscribed**
- Rockwell Land listed its P10B fixed-rate bonds on the PDEx on Wednesday — its first bond issuance in nearly 13 years and the first tranche of a P20B shelf registration program. The issuance consists of 3-year bonds at 5.5666% and 5-year bonds at 5.8595%, with the order book oversubscribed approximately five times the P7B base offer. Net proceeds will fund capex for land development and construction of existing projects including Power Plant Mall Angeles, Rockwell at IPI Center, Aruga Hotel Mactan, and Rockwell Center Bacolod. The bonds carry a PRS Aaa rating with stable outlook from PhilRatings.
- **Analysis:** The 5x oversubscription is a powerful validation of Rockwell Land's credit quality and investor confidence — especially given the elevated rate environment. Returning to the bond market after 13 years, at PRS Aaa, signals that the Alabang Town Center acquisition (P21.6B stake acquired late 2025) did not strain the balance sheet beyond investor comfort. The P20B shelf program also preserves flexibility for future capital needs without repeated SEC registration cycles. For the equity (ROCK), the bond issuance is credit-positive and removes near-term refinancing pressure, though shares at P1.81 remain range-bound.
- Stance: MONITOR ROCK . Bond issuance is positive for credit quality and project pipeline visibility. Watch for Alabang Town Center contribution to earnings.

JFC 189.30

- **JFC / FMCG Sector — FAST Logistics Urges Co-Loading to Cut Fuel Costs**
- FAST Logistics Group, which provides logistics services to FMCG companies, recommended co-loading as a practical cost management strategy amid oil price spikes driven by the Middle East conflict. CEO Manuel Onrejas stated that consolidating cargo from multiple shippers into a single vehicle reduces per-delivery cost rather than running dedicated trucks. The recommendation was made during a DTI meeting with leading FMCG companies and retailers on March 17.
- **Analysis:** This is a macro/sector read rather than a direct stock catalyst. FAST Logistics is not listed, but the read-through is significant for listed logistics-dependent plays. At Brent above $100 and diesel heading toward another price hike, freight cost inflation is an immediate margin risk for consumer staples companies — CNPF, URC, MONDE, GSMI, and food & beverage names broadly. Co-loading is a structural efficiency play but requires industry coordination. For JFC specifically, which operates 12 commissaries and a large delivery fleet, any logistics cost mitigation supports margins.
- Sector watch. Negative for FMCG margin outlook if fuel prices stay elevated. Co-loading is a partial mitigant, not a solution. Monitor CNPF, URC, MONDE for fuel cost sensitivity.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PERC 3.39

- **PetroGreen Energy Corp. (PGEC), through subsidiary BKS Green Energy Corp., formally switched on the 40MW Limbauan Solar Power Plant in San Pablo, Isabela on March 16. The facility is expected to generate 59 GWh of clean energy annually, sufficient to power ~33,000 households while offsetting 31,700 metric tons of CO2 yearly. The project was developed through Rizal Green Energy Corp., a joint venture between PGEC and Japan's Taisei Corporation, and was a winning bidder in the DOE's Second Green Energy Auction (GEA2). PGEC is the RE arm of listed PetroEnergy Resources Corp. (PTRE).**
- **Analysis:** This is a tangible RE capacity addition milestone. The GEA2-backed offtake agreement provides revenue certainty — government-backed pricing reduces merchant risk. For PTRE (listed), the commissioning adds to the group's operational capacity, pushing PetroEnergy closer to its 500MW target by 2029. The timing is strategically well-positioned given the current high oil price environment — every MW of solar online reduces grid dependence on expensive fuel-based generation.
- **MONITOR.** RE capacity additions are earnings-accretive. The high oil price backdrop makes RE increasingly competitive and supports investor appetite for clean energy exposure.

MWIDE 2.92

- **MWIDE (Megawide) — Order Book Climbs to P50B; 4PH Housing a Key Driver**
- Megawide Construction Corp. reported its order book rose 15% to P50B at end-2025, representing 3–4 years of revenue visibility. The expanded 4PH (Pambansang Pabahay Para sa Pilipino) housing projects — primarily three Cavite developments — now account for 23% of the order book. Residential is 35%, office/commercial 28%, and infrastructure 15%. Megawide also disclosed plans to redeem P1.5B in Series 5 preferred shares on April 17 as part of its debt management program, noting improved Q1 2026 debt levels. CEO Saavedra hinted at a possible shift in dividend strategy toward ordinary shareholders.
- **Analysis:** The P50B order book is the headline — it gives Megawide multi-year revenue visibility and reduces the uncertainty typical of construction cyclicality. The 4PH pivot is strategically smart: government-backed affordable housing demand is structurally large and less affected by the rate hike risk hitting the premium residential market. The preferred share redemption and debt improvement signal financial health recovery. A potential dividend shift to common shareholders — if it materializes — would be a re-rating catalyst. The P10B Pag-IBIG investment pipeline (mentioned earlier) could push the order book to P70B–P80B.